Overview and Analysis of Chavez Ravine Eviction

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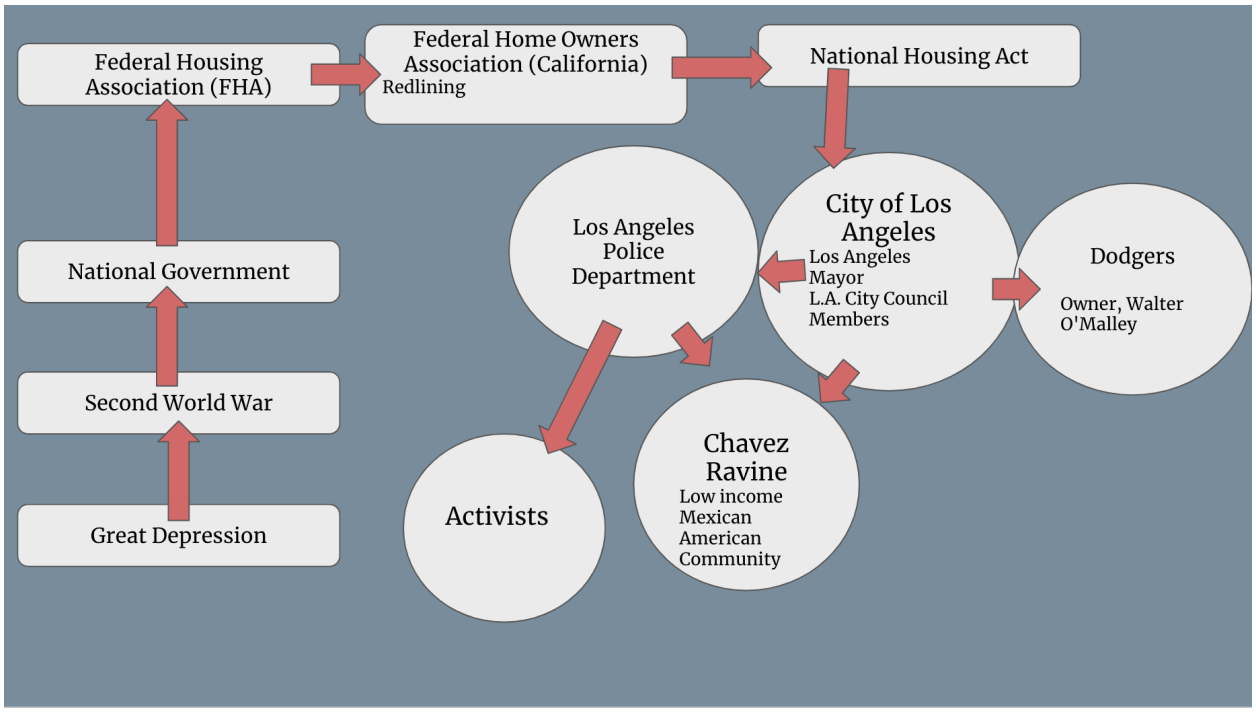
Conflict Map



The conflict that is being examined is the forced displacement of the community members of the Chavez Ravine. The main parties in the conflict are the local Los Angeles city government and the Hispanic/Latino community of the Chavez Ravine. The Secondary parties are the Brooklyn/Los Angeles Dodgers. In 1951, the Chavez Ravine was set for urban redevelopment under the National Housing Act of 1949. The Housing Act granted federal funds to Los Angeles in an attempt to expand public housing (Research Guides at Library of Congress). However, in 1953, Norris Poulson was elected as the mayor of Los Angeles. Norris was a conservative and labeled public housing as a communist in order to prevent public housing from expanding in Los Angeles. In 1957, the Los Angeles council members met up with Walter O'Malley, the owner of the Dodgers, because he wanted to survey land that would be perfect for building a new baseball stadium. He thought that the Chavez Ravine and the land surrounding it was perfect, considering its position near the freeway. Not long after, the Los Angeles City

Council approved the transfer of the land to the Dodgers. Most people in the community decided to take advantage of the lowball offer because they feared that the longer they waited, the less they would get. Some people resisted and were later labeled as “squatters.”

In the early 1950s, the city government of Los Angeles initiated a plan to clear the Chavez Ravine area to build public housing projects. Many families, primarily Mexican-Americans, had settled in Chavez Ravine and had homes there. Despite resistance from some residents, the city proceeded with the plan, promising residents compensation and new housing (Pagán). The public housing plan was later abandoned, and the land was eventually sold to the Brooklyn Dodgers baseball team owner, Walter O'Malley, who sought to build a new stadium for the team. This led to the eviction of the remaining residents of Chavez Ravine and the demolition of their homes. Instances of physical force were used by law enforcement and city officials to remove residents from their homes. Residents who resisted eviction were met with intimidation tactics and threats of arrest by police officers. In some cases, residents were forcibly removed from their homes, and their belongings were confiscated or destroyed. Additionally, community activists and organizers who supported the residents' rights were also subjected to harassment and intimidation by authorities and other parties involved in the eviction process (Pagán).

After the Second World War, the United States had extra money to invest in urban housing and public works after years of suffering from a global depression. The city of L.A. wanted to renovate the communities in the Chavez Ravine and create new housing to implement neighborhoods that were similar to white neighborhoods. As opposing views grew from Hispanic communities towards these proposed housing projects, interest groups participated in the amplification of the Red Scare and any leftist policies. As a result, the city Housing Authority

sold off to the city of L.A., leaving people who sold their homes trying to find new places to live. The Chavez Ravine incident takes place on political and geographic levels. It exemplifies systemic violence, combining structural racism, institutional coercion, economic exploitation, cultural erasure, and a lack of accountability. The predominantly Mexican-American community was forcibly displaced, reflecting broader discrimination in urban planning. Governmental power evicted residents, prioritizing commercial interests over community welfare. Cultural heritage was erased, and opposition faced minimal consequences.

Lund Matrix: Observations and Patterns

The observations listed in the Lund matrices below follow the conflict map as previously outlined.

The pattern is Los Angeles' bloody history of urban redevelopment and forced displacement of minority communities. Racial and ethnic minorities have long been displaced from their land for the sake of gentrification, redevelopment, or discriminatory state policies ("Sites and Themes | Civic Memory Working Group"). One example from the late 1800s is the genocide of the Tongva population. The Gabrielino-Tongva peoples are the indigenous population that settled on the land that now belongs to UCLA. From the 1850s through the 1930s, the Tongva people were murdered and trafficked: "When California became a state in 1850, around the time of the Gold Rush, there was this mass masculine movement west that caused massive violence within California – sexual violence, physical violence and the wiping out of native people from their lands. Seven-and-a-half million acres of land was supposed to go to native people" ("An Introduction to UCLA's Indigenous Past, Present and Future"). The land once belonging to the Tongva people is now in the hands of institutions such as UCLA and private ownership.

In another instance, the community known as “Old Chinatown” was decimated in favor of railroad construction. In the late 1800s, the creation of the Transcontinental Railroad allowed Chinese migrants to move to Los Angeles and form their own community of schools, stores, and religious institutions. However, in 1913, the California Alien Land Act was passed, which barred Asian immigrants from owning land. This combination of anti-Asian state policy, combined with negative stereotypes of Chinese people—such as their tendency to gamble and smoke opium—led to the destruction of old Chinatown (Chang). In 1935, a quarter of Old Chinatown was demolished to build the Union Station Passenger Terminal. In the 1940s, the rest of Old Chinatown was paved over for the 101 Freeway. The residents of Chinatown were forced to relocate to what is now called “New Chinatown” (“Changing Landscape”).

A third example refers to the destruction of the Pruitt Igoe housing project in 1956, which ties closely to how the Chavez Ravine was decimated in the same way. Pruitt Igoe was set as an example of a ‘failure’ because of its decline in maintenance and security, which led to the original intent of the modern public housing project to turn into an impoverished and crime-driven urban area (*The Pruitt Igoe Myth*). Towards the end, the tenants were left to blame for their environment instead of the systems of laws and urban planning that had led to the downfall and stigmatization of these residents. Likewise, the downfall of the Chavez Ravine housing project was also at the hands of the city government by their abuse of law and the use of terms such as “blighted” and “uncivilized” to stigmatize the residents (Barraclough, 194).

Overall, these three examples show the prevalent pattern of discrimination and displacement in Los Angeles amongst racial/ethnic communities at the hands of the white “American” majority. The Chavez Ravine incident falls perfectly in line with these other conflicts, showing the disregard for an established Latino community and their culture. They

were forced out of their homes and promised land that was never given back to them. The Mexican American history of the Chavez Ravine was quite literally replaced with American ideals in the creation of the Dodgers stadium, as baseball is known as “America’s favorite pastime.”

These patterns are applicable across each Lund matrix listed below.

1. **Urbicide Analysis:**

Observations	Concept
The destruction of the community of the Chavez Ravine reconstructed into Dodger Stadium	The Conditions of Urbicide (2020)
Patterns	Theories
Urban redevelopment in ethnic communities, The dynamics of destruction and reconstruction in Urban communities	Spatial lens theory politics

Urbicide is defined as the killing of communities and is unequivocally a broad and slippery concept; as stated in the Pullan article, it’s a multidisciplinary term that's often referenced in many different fields, from international relations to geography and even architecture. But our goal, like Pullan’s, isn’t to precisely identify or define exactly what urbicide is but to analyze the adverse effects urbicide had on the community of the Chavez Ravine through the Spatial lens. We must look at the three conditions of herbicide, the first being urban redevelopment as urbicide. A quote from a lecture uses these examples to prove further clarification: “Slum clearance and urban renewal projects driven by corporate power and global capitalism.” Next, we have Urbicide in war, which can be viewed as the destruction of city life in all aspects, and finally, there is terrorism as urbicide, which is seen as the targeting of a symbolic

place. When looking at turbidity through a spatial lens, a quote comes to mind from the lecture: “Conflict is about the struggle over the meaning of space and the sorting of populations.” We analyze the allocation of space in urban communities. We attempt to understand how space is restricted, appropriated, claimed, and transformed into particular ‘places.’ We must look at the parties that benefit from redistribution and those responsible for it. The lecture also questions how individuals and organizations in conflict establish spatial claims to authority. And: how are these practices adopted, contested, or resisted? The battle of the Chavez Ravine gives us the perfect conflict to analyze the contentious subject of urbicide through a spatial lens.

The Chavez Ravine battle embodies the Dynamics of destruction and reconstruction discussed in Pullan's article. It fits the condition that urban redevelopment is a form of urbicide. The reason is the Chavez Ravine was a case of redevelopment; an article titled “Chávez Ravine: A Los Angeles Story” by Jordan Mechner states, “Using the power of eminent domain, which permitted the government to purchase property from private individuals in order to construct projects for the public good, the city of Los Angeles bought up the land and leveled many of the existing buildings.” Concerning this specific conflict, when answering the question, How do individuals and organizations in conflict establish spatial claims to authority? The government held supreme authority in determining spatial claims to land. With a policy like eminent domain in its arsenal, the government could enforce a sale of land or space on any private owner or entity. A quote from Pullan's article sums up the underlying truth of the conflict: “Urbicide by redevelopment asserts in the strongest of terms the capacity of urban planning and architecture to achieve the political aims set by interests other than the local inhabitants.” The government confiscated the territory of the Chavez Ravine against the will of the people who resided to allocate it to the Dodgers, which was a private organization. They did this because they valued

the rise in tourism, which they felt would result from having the dodger present in Los Angeles over what would have been best for the community of the Chavez Ravine, and this is what the Quote from Pullan's article was alluding to.

When discussing destruction and reconstruction, a quote from Pullan's article from the president of Syria, who used war as well as means of deliberate destruction to reconstruct what he believed would be his ideal Syrian cities, stated this: "The urbicidal goal of destroying one city to make a 'better' city is echoed in a shocking statement by Syrian President Bashar al-Assad (2017): 'We have lost the best of our young people and an infrastructure that has cost us a lot of money and sweat over several generations. But in return, we have gained a healthier and more harmonious society." A major issue with destruction and reconstruction is that it's impossible to deduce whether or not the reconstruction will produce better results. The article alludes to the fact that these reconstructions tend to always discriminate after the devastation and reconstruction regardless of whether people were experiencing poverty or the individuals belonged to marginalized groups of people; they are usually displaced and cast aside to complete the project. As was the case in regards to the Chavez Ravine, the Latino community who lived there and were considered to be poor were removed, and with little regard to what happened to them after their removal. They thought very little of individuals who resided in the community of the Chavez Ravine, so they felt they could do whatever they wanted to them without consequence or pushback; an article titled "Public Purpose" and Private Gain in the Chavez Ravine" stated, "Wilkinson and other leaders of the Housing Authority assumed that the residents of the area, as impoverished "slum-dwellers," A quote from Pullans article also goes further in-depth on the affects the process destruction and reconstruction has on people who are usually from underserved communities it states "n Syrian cities the dynamic of destructive and

reconstructive urbicide is exacerbated by the scale of the devastation that presents an open canvas for some of the worst neoliberal practices of land assembly and ethno-social exclusion."

As mentioned earlier, eminent domain is one of the government's most potent tools for confiscating land and resolving spatial disputes. Eminent domain allows the government to forcibly take your property even if you refuse to sell it. Although this power the government can exercise is absolute, there is a caveat that property acquired by the government using eminent domain must be used for the public's good. The city council deemed they were doing this by allocating the land to the Dodgers instead of building public housing. When analyzing this situation, a question has to be posed: how are these practices adopted, contested, or resisted? The answer to this question regarding the Chavez Ravine was in court. Despite the council having a referendum to scrap the housing project voted on by county residents, a judge ruled the use of the land violated the public-purpose clause. But inevitably, that judge was overruled by another California Supreme Court judge, and the project would proceed as planned. The residents of the Chavez Ravine fought and resisted utilizing legal battles, protests, and media campaigns, and mapping these different means of resistance shows us how the space of the Chavez Ravine became a site of conflict and struggle. Other infringements were committed when analyzing the conflict from a spatial perspective, including the abuse of eminent domain as a legal tool to enact spatial violence. The violent eviction of residents and the reallocating of land and displacing the residents destroyed a tight-knit community; these are examples of spatial control and disruption.

2. **Trias Violentiae Analysis:**

Observations	Concept
Forced removal of the Mexican-American community of the Chavez Ravine	Trias Violentiae
Patterns	Theories

Forced displacement of minority communities	Broader understanding of urban violence

An additional combination of concept and theory that may be applied to the Chavez ravine is Schinkel's *trias violentiae*, revised by Slooter, and the theory of broader readings/ forms of urban violence.

When analyzing instances of urban violence, there are many different interpretations. Violence from "below" describes civilian violence, often as illegitimate, moral crises of the lower class. On the contrary, violence from "above" argues that public disorder is a response to structural violence, a resulting polarization of class structure, and ethnoracial segregation (Wacquant 24). Loïc Wacquant essentially argues that violence from below is caused by violence from above, claiming that seemingly unjustified violence often has structural causes. However, Luuk Slooter introduces a third form of violence, aside from "above" and "below," in order to properly understand urban violence rather than isolating each of its elements in differing interpretations. Rather than choosing to focus on which type of violence an event is predominantly classified as, Slooter builds on Schinkel's *trias violentiae* by describing the interrelations between private, state/police, and structural violence. Private violence refers to the visible violence committed by citizens, or "from below." State/police violence is considered legitimate, daily acts of sanctioning violence, a reaction to private violence. Structural violence, often invisible and unrecognized, is ingrained into everyday life and refers to phenomena such as poverty, unemployment, and discrimination.

In the Chavez Ravine case, the private violence is the protest of the residents and their refusal to leave their homes. Technically, there were no physically violent riots or revolts on behalf of the residents, but the resistance of the Chavez Ravine residents to local government and law enforcement agencies can be considered the illegitimate "criminality" that constitutes private

violence. The state/police violence describes instances of physical force used by law enforcement and city officials to remove residents from their homes. Residents who resisted eviction were reportedly met with intimidation tactics, including threats of arrest and physical removal by police officers. In some cases, residents were forcibly removed from their homes and their belongings were confiscated or destroyed. Additionally, there were reports of intimidation and harassment directed at residents who opposed the eviction and sought to defend their homes. Community activists and organizers who supported the residents' rights were also subjected to the same treatment by authorities and other parties involved in the eviction process. Thus, structural violence in regards to the Chavez Ravine is the ingrained discrimination against the Mexican-American community inhabiting the Ravine. Plowing over a community belonging to an ethnic minority, and referring to it as a "vacant shantytown" and an "eyesore," falls perfectly in line with the long history of overturning minority communities both in the United States as a whole and in Los Angeles specifically. Additionally, the displaced people were promised a place in the urban housing that was supposed to be built but was scrapped by the government due to the belief that such initiatives were communistic and un-American, further demonstrating how marginalized communities were continuously oppressed by the institutions in place.

The idea of structural violence relates to Mustafa Dikeç's thoughts on democracy and his political readings of violence, in which he argues urban uprisings expose "patterns, dynamics, and structures of exclusion and oppression that have become routine and normalized" and calls for justice and equality rather than displays of sheer criminality (7). Though the protests in the Chavez Ravine were not violent insurrections on behalf of the residents, the patterns of discrimination and oppression present in the state and systemic violence clearly portray Dikeç's view of how democracy plays into urban violence. Democracies work to the advantage of

dominant groups, perpetuating cycles of privilege, domination, and oppression. Liberal democracies, therefore, allow for power disparities, undermining the democratic value of equality. The tension created by the theory and reality of democracy thus fuels the rage in urban uprisings. Contemporary urban processes produce discontent and dissent that the established institutions of liberal democracies cannot accommodate in non-coercive ways (Dikeç 4). In the context of the Chavez Ravine, the inherent discrimination and marginalization of the Mexican-American residents—the structural violence—is perpetuated by the privilege of the white, "American" majority. The power of the majority allows them to undermine the minority, in ways such as unjustly taking their land in favor of a baseball stadium. When the Chavez Ravine residents dissent against this clear display of exploitation and exclusion, they are met with police violence because of the incapability of a liberal democracy to cope with systemic inequality; the institutions founded around equality cannot properly handle revolts that stem from inequality because the theory cannot match reality, which is why structural violence so often corresponds with state violence.

Overall, the concept of *trias violentiae* and structural violence—as well as the underlying democratic explanation—relates to a broader understanding of urban violence. It corresponds to a sea of literature focusing on the classification of violence, specifically how "broad" or "narrow" an interpretation of violence should be. The *trias violentiae* model and other political readings of violence are part of the broad category, in which other forms of violence besides just physical force are considered. The "violence from above" and "violence from below" provides the basis for *trias violentiae* and does this well because the "above" category goes beyond violence between individual actors and works to explain the underlying factors that cause violence. *Trias violentiae* goes further to show how all types of violence—both visible and

invisible— interact and influence each other. Essentially, the *trias violentiae* model takes a broad approach to classifying types of violence and joins a more general group of literature that expands the meaning of urban violence beyond the visible and physical.

3. **Life Cycle Model Analysis:**

Observations	Concept
Chavez Ravine tenants protested against the city government and were forcefully displaced at the end without comparable compensation	Life-cycle model (Newburn, 2021)
Patterns	Theories
Denunciation of public housing programs; disregard over the people for privatization and political leverage during the process of urban planning	Structural sociology and social psychology literature; broader conditions and importance of group identity in terms of violence

The life cycle model by Tim Newburn provides specificities on the context, dynamics, nature, and, more importantly, the responses and impact of the Chavez Ravine eviction. In discussing beyond the contextualization of the violent event, this part of the report will focus on analyzing the event through its dynamics, nature, and the consequences based on the model. We will also reinterpret the original intent of the model from analyzing riots to protests, since the Chavez Ravine eviction did not evoke riots. The dynamics and nature of the model will focus on protests that had happened, but the responses and impact of the model would apply both to the protests and the general scope of the Chavez Ravine incident.

The dynamics of the life cycle models describes the immediate start of the protests and how it grows, spreads, and ends (Newburn 67). The precipitating events of the protests are the “below-market cash offers" to the Chavez Ravine families in order to buyout the land of the

housing project, which has led to some acquiring debt because of the disparity between the amount of offer and the price of housing in the rest of the Los Angeles city (UCLA library). As the California Housing Authority (CHA) continued to dwindle their pricing offer, the critical flashpoint of the protests was when the city used eminent domain to bypass the buyout process as the ultimate pressure on the residents to sell their housing project. This triggered the first wave of protests where residents, unwilling to sell their homes, attended the City Planning Commission's hearings in April 1951 and made placards to demand the city to recognize their rights as homeowners ("Chavez Ravine"). Linked developments that incited tensions were the families continuous resistance towards the buyout offers by city governments. As such, the protests developed when families continued to live in the projects despite the repeated threats of lowering the offers and the initial wave of demolitions in 1952 (UCLA library). This then triggered the second flashpoint where the Los Angeles city attorney's office ordered the families to leave their homes in a month, otherwise they would be forcefully evicted. Leading to the extent and end of the protests, the few remaining families stayed until they were removed without consent and arrested by the Los Angeles's police department. The bulldozing of the Chavez Ravine's homes and the departure of the last remaining family's encampment protest afterwards contributed to the definitive end of the disorder, specifically signaling the spatial and temporal end to the protests (Ortiz).

The nature of the life cycle model focuses on who were the people in the protests, what was involved, and the policing and controlling tactics of the protests (Newburn 66). The main participants of the protests were the Angeleno community of the Chavez Ravine, who were proud of their self-made, independent community that developed without the support of the city's leadership. Their feelings and perceived motivations stemmed from the collective, cultural

identity that spans over generations and dates back to the Mexican Revolution (UCLA library). Another participant of the protests were the community activists and organizers that supported the residents' rights, such as the City Center District Improvement Association (CCDIA) that organized a political coalition of property owners and tenants from the neighborhood. What was involved in the nature of the protests was overall peaceful and solemn, with families refusing to leave their homes and willingly staying put to fight for their displacement and legal right to the land. However, the policing and control strategies changed the way protests unfolded by diminishing the volume it had around the tenants and the public to fight for the injustice and insensitive erasure of the Chavez Ravine community. The authoritative role of the city government allowed for its agencies, like the police and fire department, to arrest residents and set their houses on fire (Johnson, 60).

Finally, the responses and impact of the life cycle model describes the nature of responses and the immediate to long-term consequences of the protests from various institutions (Newburn 66). The first category is the political opinion and media response to the protest, of which one of them was the "Committee to Save Chavez Ravine For The People" activists who successfully gathered signatures to force a public referendum election of the Chavez Ravine. They contributed to the narrative that the destruction of the Chavez Ravine project for the Dodgers stadium should be kept for public use instead of privatization, including publishing a fact sheet that details the violation of the public purpose of the land (Online Archive of California). On the contrary, the Los Angeles voters rejected the public housing program in favor of the stadium under "Proposition B", persuaded by the media where celebrities, sports stars, and civic leaders participated and supported the City's contract with the Dodgers. This cleared the way for the Dodgers to begin their construction of a stadium through the use of media to change the rhetoric

of the public in favor of the Dodger stadium's future prospects (Shyer). The penal and public policy responses during the protests include Judge Arnold Praeger ruling the Chavez Ravine Stadium contract as illegal because it violated the "public-purpose clause" under the California Superior Court. The State Supreme Court, on the other hand, overturned and upheld the contract, allowing for the immediate consequence of selling the entire area of the Chavez Ravine projects— which included underground oil rights and overhead air rights— to the CEO of the Dodgers team, Walter O' Malley, and proceeded to dismantle the Chavez Ravine housing project and began their construction of the Dodger stadium (Johnson 60). As a result, the long-term impact of this incident was the displacement of 7,500 families which would take three generations for only a fraction of the families to gain back a comparable economic level. As assets were destroyed, these families were stripped of their freedom to create opportunities and to have the power to maintain financial and general stability (Johnson 61-62). However, the city and the private sector's understanding of the incident after decades have passed forwarded nothing beyond the words of respect in which the Dodgers team would pay during their games; as the city proceeded to construct an aerial gondola at the Dodger Stadium, evoking the same form of gentrification over marginalized, ethnic communities as before (Los Angeles Times).

The theory behind the life cycle model is the sociological, psychological literature and broader conditions or importance of group identity in terms of violence. The model derives from structural sociology and social psychology approaches that have been previously used to analyze the cause and consequence of riots, whereas Newburn's life cycle model emphasizes on the consequences of riots (Newburn 60-62).

Reflection

By analyzing the Chavez Ravine eviction through the lenses of urbicide, *trias violentiae*, and the life cycle model, we have a multifaceted understanding of the forces at play. The concept of urbicide establishes the intentional construction and reconstruction of urban spaces, most often driven by the opportunity for economic and political gain. The Chavez Ravine conflict is the core example of this concept in using eminent domain to displace the Mexican-American community for the construction of the Dodger Stadium. The concept underlines the political power dynamics and how governments prioritize economic interests over the well being of these marginalized communities, making the concept the most optimal for our event compared to others since its structural definition of urban violence under urban redevelopment directly corresponds to the construction of the Dodger stadium over the Chavez Ravine housing project.

The *trias violentiae* model deepens our understanding by labeling violence into private, state/police, and structural forms. We see some of these types of violence in the case of the Chavez Ravine: the residents' resistance as private violence, the forceful actions of law enforcement as both state and police violence, and the systematic oppression against Mexican-Americans living in the United States as structural violence. The model demonstrates how different forms of violence interplay to systemically impact low income, under-resourced communities and strip them of the resources and power. Thus, the model has a nuanced and comprehensive perspective of the event by looking at it in differing levels of violence and how they affected each other. Though it is not as directly correlated to our event like the urbicide concept, it is a competent model to examine the violence of the Chavez Ravine eviction through its critical form of analysis.

Finally, the life cycle model exemplifies the dynamics, nature, and consequences of the Chavez Ravine protests. It illustrates how the protests grew in response to unjust policies and

forceful evictions but is ultimately suppressed by the city's authoritative actions. The model describes in detail the protests, speaking on the shared culture and identity that motivated the residents to protest against their forced displacement. Most importantly, the model explains the consequences of urban uprisings, which is not discussed much in literature, of the large economic and social displacement for families, a loss of cultural heritage, and ongoing disempowerment of racial minorities. The model emphasizes the importance of understanding the broader factors that drive collective actions and the long term ramifications on community stability, but the model lacks the ability to have more of a critical analysis due to its all encompassing description of urban violence from context to the aftermath.

Ultimately, there is a pattern of displacement and discrimination in Los Angeles after examining the Chavez Ravine event through multiple lenses. The destruction of communities like the Chavez Ravine is a continuing issue that reflects the larger institutional threat to low income minority communities and their battles against systematic oppression. Understanding these patterns through these analyses is important to ensure urban redevelopment does not come at the cost of people and their communities.

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